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Norris Turney

Saxophonist Norris Turney was born in Wilmington, Ohio on September 8, 1921. He first found work with territory bands led by Jeter Pillars and Tiny Bradshaw, later moving to New York to work with Billy Eckstine. Norris also excelled on flute and clarinet and was tapped to sub for Johnny Hodges in 1969. He took over the lead alto chair in the Ellington Orchestra after Johnny passed away, and led the reed section until 1973. Norris has performed with the Savoy Sultans, George Wein's All Stars, and in numerous Broadway shows. His playing manages to bridge the world of swing and bebop, and he is a familiar presence at jazz festivals and parties across the country. His latest recording is "Big, Sweet and Blue."

Norris was interviewed at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 11, 1997, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Today we're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Aspen Colorado at the Jerome Jazz Festival. I'm very pleased to have Norris Turney with me today, who is a saxophonist and woodwind player of much experience. I wanted to read something that a pretty well known jazz writer said about you in talking about your recordings and so forth. He said, "Norris Turney has a fine sound and style on alto sax, flute and clarinet. His alto combines swing era urgency and fluidity with bebop era exactness and technical expertise." Do you agree with that?

NT: Sure.

MR: Sure. Sounds like a pretty good write up to me. It seems like last night in your performance I heard — actually a bit of that stood out from some of the other players in my ears is that you had a lot of blues inflection in your playing but occasionally there were bebop licks too.

NT: Yeah. Well I always liked the blues. Blues is my favorite sound, always has been.

MR: In growing up in Ohio, was that a part of the music that you heard as a child?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Did your parents have blues recordings, or where did you hear most of your music?

NT: At the player piano. And we had some blues on that. And then we got a radio. And we used to listen to big bands, Fletcher Henderson, Earl Hines, Basie when he first went to New York, and all the big bands you know, Jimmie Lunceford.

MR: Radio was a huge part of the way information was spread at the time, right?

NT: Oh, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Was there a certain point that you decided, I'm going to be a musician?

NT: I think I was born a musician because when we were kids my brother and my sister and I used to roll up paper horns out of newspaper. My brother played pots and pans, my sister

was taking piano lessons. So we had a little concert every week. We were very young then.

MR: Would you actually play tunes or were you kind of just improvising?

NT: Improvise, yeah.

MR: What was your first instrument? The saxophone?

NT: The C melody saxophone.

MR: Ah, yeah. Those kind of went out of favor.

NT: Yeah.

MR: When was the last time that you actually played a C melody saxophone?

NT: I don't know. I have one at home that a friend gave me, he passed away, but he gave me a C melody saxophone and a Gemeinhardt flute.

MR: Well the C melody was good because I guess you could read the piano music.

NT: Yeah.

MR: Did you take lessons in school or were you mostly —

NT: Yeah. I started taking lessons when I was in seventh grade.

MR: At what point did you get away from the actual written music and start kind of improvising?

NT: Well I always improvised.

MR: Yeah.

NT: Yeah. So that was at the very beginning you know. Even after I learned to read music, I still improvised.

MR: The swing music of the time that might have been coming through Ohio, did you have a chance to go out and hear any of the bands that you were hearing on the radio?

NT: Well later after I graduated from high school I heard a couple of bands. I think I heard Artie Shaw's band when he had Billie Holiday with him. And Lionel Hampton. And that's about it.

MR: This was let's see, late 30s?

NT: Yeah. Late 30s and early 40s.

MR: So the swing era was kind of in full swing I should say?

NT: Yeah. A lot of bands out there.

MR: Did you have experience — what would World War II bring for you?

NT: World War II? Well during the war I was in a band in Cincinnati, Ohio, at the Cotton Club. And we played there, we played maybe three or four sessions a day.

MR: For dancing?

NT: Yeah. Dancing and the floor show.

MR: And then you started — did you ever have to work non musical jobs to get by?

NT: Oh yeah. During the war I worked at Curtiss Wright, and made airplane engines, and swept the floor, mopped the floor.

MR: Played at night? Played gigs at night?

NT: Yeah. When I was in high school I used to shine shoes. My father got me a job at a couple of barber shops shining shoes.

MR: What did your father do for a living?

NT: He was a laborer.

MR: Have a big family?

NT: Five. My brother and sister and my mother and father.

MR: Gee by the mid 40s then you started playing with some fairly well known names: Tiny Bradshaw and was this road work?

NT: Oh yeah.

MR: It was like time to leave home and go out?

NT: Yeah, well, I'd been working at the Cotton Club for maybe a year or so, and I left there and went to St. Louis when I joined the Jeter Pillars Orchestra. You ever heard of them?

MR: Yeah.

NT: Very good. Excellent. And I worked with Jeter I guess about a year. And then I left him and went to join Tiny Bradshaw. And after Tiny Bradshaw I joined Billy Eckstine's band. And that was the end of my road work for a while, I went back home.

MR: What was life like on the road in those days? Was it mostly bus travel first of all?

NT: Yeah, bus. Sometimes we took the train.

MR: What about accommodations at that time?

NT: The accommodations were terrible you know. We couldn't stay in hotels then. We had to go across the tracks and stay at people's houses. As a matter of fact the first hotel I stayed in, a white hotel, was in Atlanta, Georgia, I was playing with Ray Charles. And they had just opened it up, that's why we stayed there.

MR: That was in the 60s, right?

NT: Yeah, that was 1967.

MR: Well when you would get to a town with let's say Billy Eckstine, was someone in the group responsible for going to the other side of the tracks and trying to find —

NT: Yeah, it was somebody who was there, who lived there, would put us in different people's homes.

MR: Oh. So they knew you were coming.

NT: Yeah.

MR: And they'd come down and they made a few dollars off of that because you had to pay, or someone in the orchestra had to pay for putting you up.

NT: Yeah but we paid for our own accommodations in those days. We paid for our own.

MR: Well by the time you got to the end of the week, what kind of salary were you making in those days?

NT: Well with Billy Eckstine I think I made more than I'd ever made, I made twenty-five dollars a night. Worked almost every night.

MR: I guess for those times that was — you could have done worse.

NT: It wasn't too bad.

MR: And you were doing what you liked. Were you playing alto?

NT: Yeah. I played lead alto.

MR: How much chance did you get in those bands to get up and solo?

NT: Well I had a few solos in every band I played in. Maybe a ballad or jump blues.

MR: Were there certain artists at the time on record that you were being influenced by?

NT: Oh yeah. As a matter of fact I was always being influenced by Johnny Hodges and Benny Carter and Willie Smith that played lead with Jimmy Lunceford's band and later on he played with the Harry James band.

MR: Some great people there.

NT: Oh, yeah.

MR: When was your first chance to get on record? Was it with Eckstine or even before that?

NT: Yeah, I think it was with Eckstine. It was during the great record strike.

MR: During it?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Oh, how did that work?

NT: Well I don't know. We walked up many, many flights of steps to the studio. Petrillo had everybody closed up back in those days.

MR: So those particular recordings you made that day, they probably weren't released until after the strike was over.

NT: No. They were all on national records.

MR: Did you do any of those V disks?

NT: No.

MR: So you moved back to Ohio.

NT: Yeah, after I leave these bands I went back home.

MR: Enough of this bus stuff, huh?

NT: Yeah. I'm sorry I left, because they were on their way to California. I'd never been to California before. So I regret that to this day.

MR: Yeah?

NT: Yeah.

MR: What happened when you got back home?

NT: Well I got a little group together, worked around Ohio, Kentucky, Indiana. And then I went back to New York, I guess about 19— 50s, in the 50s. Yeah, early 50s I'd say. I had a group around New York for a while, and as a matter of fact I went from New York to Philadelphia, and I lived in Philadelphia about six years, and played with Elmer Snowden.

MR: The small group thing you were doing, was it strictly jazz? Was it more rhythm & blues? Was it dance music?

NT: It was jazz. And you could dance to it.

MR: Yeah?

NT: Sure.

MR: It was jazz but you could dance to it.

NT: Sure.

MR: That was such a big part of this music, the dancing part of it?

NT: Oh, yeah, sure. That's why we were playing jazz, but the most important thing is for you to have in jazz to dance, is to have the right tempos, where people feel it. Because when I worked in the Cotton Club in Cincinnati we had a great little band, about ten pieces.

MR: And you knew if the people weren't getting up off their seats that you weren't doing something right?

NT: Yeah, they always got up.

MR: Or if they got up and then sat down, that was the worst.

NT: I never saw them do that.

MR: That's good. Yeah, the tempo I mean makes a huge difference and it's not exactly the notes, especially for dancers.

NT: Yeah.

MR: Well you've gone through some really famous groups. And during the 50s you said you lived in Philadelphia, a good music city.

NT: Yeah.

MR: How did rock & roll affect your career?

NT: Oh it affected it quite a bit, yeah. As a matter of fact I never have — I remember when it first started I was in Philadelphia and I worked with Bull Moose Jackson, and he had a big band. And they had a Rock band there. One answer is probably they were loud. They were good and loud. As a matter of fact when I worked with Bull Moose, Coltrane was in the band, John Coltrane was in his band, and he played the Apollo Theater. John Coltrane left and went to join Monk.

MR: Well I've heard even players like Coltrane did walk the bar and all that kind of thing.

NT: No. He didn't do that.

MR: Don't think so, huh?

NT: I never saw him do it.

MR: No I haven't either but—

NT: When I played with Paul Weaver's band he used to walk the bar.

MR: Is there a technique for walking the bar?

NT: Taking care that you don't fall.

MR: Kick people's drinks over.

NT: Yeah you know, the first time I ever saw a guy doing that kind of stuff was in New York at a place called the Apollo Bar. This guy played tenor, I can't think of his name. He'd go walk around the block, still blowing. Get on a bus, come back, still blowing.

MR: And hopefully came back in the door and he was still in the same place in the tune.

NT: That's right. Meantime the rhythm section's still banging, banging away.

MR: That's wild. How did the thing with Ray Charles come about?

NT: Let's see. I don't really remember. I think I was playing up at Minton's in New York. Oh no, I remember now, somebody recommended me to Ray. And he was going to Australia. So I'd never been to Australia before, so I took it, just on that. And I went to back to Australia about three more times with Duke Ellington.

MR: Was the Ray Charles Orchestra a fun group to play with?

NT: Um hum. A very good band. Johnny Coles was there, that baritone player was there from his first band. He had a good band.

MR: Before we get to Ellington, do you consider yourself, were you heavily into bebop at that time? I mean, can you describe your own playing as opposed to someone else describing it?

NT: Well, just like most people playing horns back in those days, everybody was influenced by Charlie Parker. Everybody was trying to play like Bird. Some people even started shooting up dope so they could play like Bird.

MR: Thought that that was the secret.

NT: Yeah. And I used to try to copy him a little bit, as a matter of fact I didn't know anything about Charlie Parker until Sonny Stitt alerted me to him. Sonny was in Tiny's band before I was. He asked me, he used to come to Cincinnati a lot. He asked me if I heard this cat named Charlie Parker. I'd never heard of him before. And then I heard him later. I tried to play like him but that wasn't my thing. No. I went back to my old original stuff.

MR: Which is?

NT: The way I play now.

MR: Which is a combination of blues and — So you were with Ray Charles, and in 1969 you started subbing for Johnny Hodges?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Johnny got ill?

NT: Yeah. He was out about two weeks. And I was working at Minton's then I remember, and they called me up there, I was working with a small band. And they called me at Minton's and they said Johnny was going to be sick. Because I think probably Stanley Dance had something to do with it. You know Stanley Dance, don't you?

MR: Yeah. So he's the one that may have recommended you?

NT: Yeah I think so.

MR: Well you were certainly aware of Johnny Hodges for many years before that. How did you feel stepping into his place?

NT: I had no feelings about it at all. It was just a gig. I figured I'd be gone in two weeks and coming back home. But I never was frightened or nothing like that.

MR: Yeah? Well good. Did the rest of the orchestra, were they supportive of you in that position?

NT: Yeah I think so. You know the second night I was with them they played a sacred concert, and I never heard that music before. So they pulled all this music out. So I read it, Cootie was sitting right behind me and said, "Man, that boy can read."

MR: Yeah. Because a lot of those fellows just had the charts all memorized, right?

NT: Oh, yeah.

MR: Yeah. You know a number of people have said, and I've read a couple of times that the Ellington group could be just swinging like crazy one night, and the next night not sound half as good.

NT: Oh, yeah.

MR: Or even in the middle of a night, go from one to the next.

NT: Like everybody else, they had their ups and downs. But when they're up, nobody could touch them. I remember one time we played a gig in Binghamton, England I think. And riding the bus all day from London, everybody was tired. So that night we got to the gig and everybody got ripped. That's the best I've ever heard them sound.

MR: Yeah? In Binghamton, New York.

NT: Binghamton, England.

MR: Oh you were in England. I see.

NT: I think it's Binghamton, on the ocean.

MR: Okay. You went from London to this place. All right I misunderstood. So you got obviously some overseas work. And this was after Hodges died and you became the lead alto player. That lasted for what, about four years?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Well it certainly was an institution.

NT: Yeah.

MR: Who was in the saxophone section the first time you played with them?

NT: Harry Carney, Russell Procope, Harold Ashby, Paul Gonsalves and me.

MR: Good company. You were able to play at his seventieth birthday concert?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Was that at Carnegie Hall?

NT: Well we made a recording for the seventieth birthday. I don't remember whether it was at Carnegie Hall. It probably was.

MR: What's it been like since then? You left them in '73.

NT: In '73. I played the Broadway theater for ten years. I played "Raisin'" I played "Ain't Misbehavin," I played "Guys and Dolls," "and "Sophisticated Ladies." That was about ten years there.

MR: Yeah? That's a good steady gig for musicians.

NT: Yeah. That's the best you can get in New York.

MR: Yeah? A lot of competition for that.

NT: Yeah.

MR: Is it the same way you get into that as it is to, you know, you get a recommendation?

NT: Well how I got started, a friend of mine, George Dorsey, was trying to get that same show. So I just bought a new Volvo then. The show was in Philadelphia. We drove up to Philadelphia and met the leader, the music conductor. So he talked to the contractors. And that's how George and I got it.

MR: Did it ever get to be tiresome night after night?

NT: Well yeah. The only show I played that didn't get tiresome was "Ain't Misbehavin,'" a small band.

MR: Was that where you were right on stage?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. I saw that show, and they had the band right on the stage.

NT: Yeah.

MR: It makes you pay attention a little more.

NT: The piano player.

MR: Hank Jones?

NT: Hank Jones was on piano, Seldon Powell on tenor, I played alto and clarinet. Richard Jones played trumpet. Nice little band, yeah.

MR: Good gig.

NT: Yeah.

MR: Tell me about the Savoy Sultans.

NT: Oh, yeah my wife told me Panama called yesterday. He's down in Florida now.

MR: Yeah, how's he doing?

NT: He's doing okay. He's very sick. But he's out there now.

MR: That must have been a fun gig to be on.

NT: Yeah it was.

MR: Talk about swinging and dancers.

NT: Yeah. But it was really nice. He made a couple of tours, made a few recordings. Panama Francis and his Savoy Sultans. Most of those guys that were in that band now are all passed away.

MR: Who was in that group while you were there?

NT: Well the piano player, Red Richards, he's still living. And the bass player is dead. The lead trumpet player is dead. The other trumpet player, Pauly DeGuy, he's still living. Let's see, Panama's still with us. The alto player passed away. We had two altos and a tenor. I think the tenor players are gone too.

MR: Did that group get recorded?

NT: Yeah. We made two albums in Paris.

MR: What's it like to play overseas? Is it any different than playing in the States?

NT: Well the people appreciate it more over there. You know, basically I guess over there it's like being in the symphony you know?

MR: It's more like classical music?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever think of staying over there?

NT: Yeah I've thought about it but I haven't done it yet. Too late now.

MR: What's the music scene like in your home town?

NT: Well it's fair. Not too good. Not as good as it used to be. But I get a few gigs, I do a little traveling, collect my Social Security and my pension and go on.

MR: Now your pension, I'm glad you brought that up actually. You know musicians traditionally have not worked under the same benefits that a person who works in a factory or whatever. Do you have a pension from the union?

NT: Yeah. Usually you get your pension from playing Broadway shows and recording.

MR: Okay.

NT: Yeah. So I played Broadway for ten years.

MR: But as far as —

NT: But Duke didn't pay into the pension fund so I got no pension from him, or Ray Charles. No band leaders pay into the pension fund. But when you get on Broadway, they have to pay into it.

MR: Right. It's a little more regulated. I sometimes wonder about musicians like Harry Carney and so forth, who spent all those years on that band, if he had wanted to retire, could he have just stopped playing? Unless he had saved up.

NT: Well he wouldn't have got any pension from Duke Ellington. Because Russell Procope went down to the union to see if they had a pension account. He never paid into it.

MR: Nothing.

NT: He said no pension.

MR: Has there been a dark side to the music business for you or any people you know, that we don't hear about as much? Is it a tough life in some regards?

NT: Oh yeah, it's a very tough life. A very tough life. Whenever I teach I tell my students, don't depend on music to make a living by. Go to school and get a degree. Because you can't make it on music, unless you're going into rock & roll or something like that.

MR: The music of the 40s, the popular music was swing, so that you could make a living at that time I guess.

NT: Oh yes. You'd go from band to band.

MR: Was there much room in the studio scene for black musicians let's say during the 40s?

NT: No. Not even on Broadway or in the studios. There were maybe two or three token guys who made all the studio gigs. As a matter of fact I never even thought about that. And there was a lot of things I didn't know about, the union, I didn't know about the pension, I didn't know about the hospitalization. I just happened to look up on it.

MR: Well the musician union was certainly a huge part of music back then. I don't know if it's as strong nowadays. If you were in it back then I guess it may pay some dividends for you. And you probably have to do a fair amount of traveling these days to work?

NT: Sure.

MR: And is it Wilmington you live in?

NT: No, I live in Kettering, Ohio. It's about 36 miles southwest of Wilmington.

MR: But you're not going to get six nights of work in Kettering.

NT: Oh no. I don't expect it.

MR: Right.

NT: We just live there. It's a very nice, quiet, peaceful place. We just live there.

MR: Yeah.

NT: I worked in Kettering every now and then at a place called Fay's Pavillion, right down the road from us, it's a new place. I opened it up. But there are a lot of small clubs around Kettering, but the money is terrible.

MR: Right

NT: No way in the world I'd work for thirty, forty, fifty dollars a night.

MR: That's more just for like to keep your chops up. Let me go back to Ellington for a minute. What was he like to work for?

NT: He was all right. He was nice, yeah. Of course after he became ill he got a little edgy I think. But nobody knew he was that sick. I didn't know he was that sick. But one day he

gave me a chance to blow. I was in the band about six weeks and we were playing in Lionel, Iowa. And I'd been practicing my flute every day. He called me to his dressing room one night and he says, "Come in and bring your flute in, man." So he started playing something on the piano. So I played my heart out. So he wrote me a tune called "Flap." That's how "Flap" was born.

MR: Well that's an honor. Yeah, great. I see you have a fairly recent record out.

NT: Yeah. It's not — I guess about a year, or a couple of years. I was supposed to do another one last month but he didn't call me. But even there's one after that I made with Jody Christian in Chicago. You ever heard of him? The piano player? Jody Christian?

MR: Oh, no, I thought you said Charlie Christian.

NT: No, Jody Christian. A very fine pianist.

MR: Yeah?

NT: Yeah. And we made another.

MR: Is it on a certain label?

NT: It's on Delmark.

MR: There's a lot of product out there these days and it's kind of hard to find your space with all the jazz floating around out there. I hope it does well. When you go to make an album, do you sit down and collect a whole bunch of tunes and put them in a certain order and figure out what's going to be a good balance?

NT: Yeah well usually we know, usually we know in advance what you're going to do. Certain tunes go around in your head. And you discuss it, try it and see if it works, if it doesn't work you try something else.

MR: How much time do you usually get in the studio to do an album?

NT: Well the album that I made, there's no time limit. We just stayed there all day and half the night, you know, until we finished it. But in New York you have like a certain period of time to do it in. Of course nobody sticks to that time anyway. You do it until it's good.

MR: That's good. You said you teach some students now and then. If you're trying to teach them to improvise, do you have a way that you can put it into words.

NT: No. I've always believed that that's something that you can't teach. To improvise, you have to be born with it in you.

MR: Yeah?

NT: Yeah. That's a God given gift. You can tell somebody, write a solo and play it, but you can't teach people to improvise.

MR: Well what if you've got somebody who really wants to do it, and they obviously don't have it? How do you tell them: "You haven't got it"? Or do you just let them find out for themselves?

NT: Yeah. Well I listen to them. Because most of the students that I've taught, they try to play like me. But that's not improvisation. That's copying. Improvising is something that comes from within you.

MR: When you are improvising on a standard, are you playing — well I'm not sure how to put this — are you playing mostly by ear? Or are you thinking of the chord changes that are going on?

NT: Well most of the things I play I know the chord changes anyway, so I can do just about anything I want to.

MR: Yeah.

NT: Yeah. I don't have to think about the chord changes, unless it's a new tune that I haven't played before.

MR: Do you play any keyboard to help you learn?

NT: Yeah, I took piano lessons before I took saxophone lessons. Yeah. About a year.

MR: What about studio work over the years? Did you ever play jingles or get into any of that studio scene?

NT: No. Didn't get into that. That sure is the big time scene in New York.

MR: Yeah, right.

NT: Some guys tell me, wow, ten thousand I made. And some guys are getting pensions as high as four thousand dollars a month. You see I wasn't hip to that.

MR: Yeah they were doing three sessions a day sometimes.

NT: That's right.

MR: What's in the future for you, coming up?

NT: Well just the same thing I'm doing now.

MR: Yeah?

NT: Play a little bit, relax, I'm not a great television fan. I like to watch sports and I like to drive my car. You know, nothing — I'm 76 now, and I really am semi-retired.

MR: You've seen a few years in the music business.

NT: Yeah.

MR: Well it's nice that these parties are around, that you can get out occasionally and see some of your old friends.

NT: Yeah. This is my third year for this Jerome Festival. Really nice.

MR: Well when you get that schedule, when you get here, it must be interesting to look and see — who am I going to play with this year.

NT: Yeah. Ralph called me before I came out here and asked who I wanted to play with, and I said anybody, man, makes no difference. All you guys are great. I don't care.

MR: Did you ever get in a situation in any of these parties where someone calls a tune and you don't really know.

NT: Well if I don't know it I tell them I don't know that.

MR: Right. So pick something else.

NT: That's right. I don't know that.

MR: Well that's good rather than try to fumble your way through it.

NT: You have to really know, you know after I go over it a few times — but on the spur of the moment I don't do that. If I don't know it I don't play it. Let somebody else play it who knows it.

MR: If you were to be able to make a tour of the world, and make like a couple of different stops to play in, have you been to places in the world that you'd love to go back to?

NT: Yeah, a place in — I went there about three times with Duke — Bangkok.

MR: Bangkok?

NT: Yeah.

MR: No kidding.

NT: Yeah Bangkok. Great town man.

MR: Now wasn't Bangkok where the king, or whoever they called him, was a jazz fan?

NT: Yeah. We met him.

MR: Yeah? Did he play?

NT: No he didn't play.

MR: He just loved the music.

NT: Yeah I like Bangkok, I like Hong Kong. In the States I like Chicago. But after I've been in New York City for thirty years, I don't want anything in the City. Thirty years in New York, I said I want to be out where I can hear the birds sing.

MR: Do you listen to a lot of music these days?

NT: Yeah we have a station, Miami University, they have a jazz station and they play good jazz all day long.

MR: Do you hear new stuff that you like, that perks your ear up.

NT: Every now and then. Basically stuff like Basie, Jimmy Lunceford, Benny Goodman, John Coltrane, you know people like that. It's background. Until I turn on the T.V. and I turn it off.

MR: Until that game's on.

NT: Yeah and that's that.

MR: Which is your favorite sport?

NT: My favorite sport is football.

MR: Yeah. So we'll know tomorrow, if you run off the stage, that you'll be going up to your room to check on the football game. Right?

NT: Oh definitely, yeah.

MR: Who is your team these days?

NT: I like the Green Bay Packers.

MR: Yeah?

NT: But you know the number one team is Colorado, isn't it?

MR: Yeah, well Denver, right?

NT: Yeah.

MR: Undefeated. Yeah. I'm a fan too.

NT: Are you? Okay.

MR: I'm a Giants fan which isn't very much fun a lot.

NT: Yeah, I know. But you know Green Bay, they've done pretty good. They lost two games so far.

MR: Well it's a good pastime.

NT: Yeah it is.

MR: And I know a lot of musicians are sports fans, in fact some of the big bands used to actually have little baseball teams.

NT: Oh, yeah, that's right. Duke had one. Basie had one too I think, a softball team. Do you like basketball?

MR: Yes sir.

NT: Yeah, me too. Chicago?

MR: Celtics. Again, not a good team to root for in the last few years. But got to be a fan and stick with it.

NT: Oh, yeah.

MR: Well I've been fascinated to talk to you, and is there anything that I haven't asked you that you'd care to —

NT: Well this about covers it you know. I can't think of anything else. Of course I worked in many, many small groups, especially in Ohio, they're all very good groups, local groups.

MR: Do you have any recollection of a gig, or a series of gigs that was just plain a disaster that you couldn't wait until they were over.

NT: Oh no not really. Because I enjoy playing the music so much. Although there is some things that weren't too good, but the music overwhelmed all of that.

MR: Well that's good to hear. Well great. I hope you have a good gig tonight. Did you bring your flute and clarinet with you?

NT: No.

MR: You're just doing the alto thing, huh?

NT: No I haven't played flute for a long time. Or clarinet. They asked me to play flute on my next record date. But I haven't played it for quite a while.

MR: Do you work with Russ Dantzler, out of New York?

NT: Yeah, Russ, yeah. He got me a tour of Germany this year I think it was, or last year.

MR: Well you're in good company with him. He's got Benny Waters.

NT: And the fiddle player, what's his name?

MR: Claude.

NT: Claude, yeah. That Claude is scheduled, man, doing every day.

MR: He's out there. Actually he's going to be up in our area in November, and I'm going to get to play with him actually, so I'm looking forward to that.

NT: Yeah, okay. Well Claude, he's almost ninety, isn't he?

MR: He'll be ninety in February. Doesn't look it. Well thanks for your time today.

NT: Hey, thank you.

MR: And I'll be listening tonight, and play some hot blues licks for me.

NT: Yeah, I will.

MR: All right.